Behind the recording



Simon Fox during the Pori Sinfonietta recording sessions. Photograph: Miikka Kiminki / SK.
Restored reconstruction of the newspaper cover photograph, using scans and a related original.

FROM THE PAGES OF SATAKUNNAN KANSA

A producer’s ear

In September 2014, Finnish newspaper Satakunnan Kansa visited Simon Fox’s recording sessions with Pori Sinfonietta. This account revisits Jarmo Huida’s feature, with selected quotations translated from Finnish.

“Simon Fox-Gál is a magician.”

So begins Huida’s feature, written during the recording of Selim Palmgren’s piano concertos. Watching Simon work from a small table in the foyer of the Promenadi concert hall, Huida describes a musician’s astonishment at how much the producer hears through his headphones while following the score.

For Simon, that concentration depends on the atmosphere around the sessions:

> *“We aim to produce music at the highest possible level, and that isn’t possible if everyone is tired, irritated or afraid that I’ll shout ‘Stop’. I try to create the most relaxed atmosphere possible while the musicians concentrate fully on the details of their playing.”*

The article explores the distinction between a concert and a recording. Simon describes the latter as a “virtual concert”: a way of presenting the music, performance and artists in their best light, creating an ideal performance that never happened in quite that form.

His background as a cellist and chamber musician informs the process. Listening to several musical lines at once is familiar territory; the producer must understand what he hears immediately, as music, before deciding what needs attention.

Above all, Simon places the performers’ work at the centre:

> *“The artists may have worked for decades to reach that level. I come in at that peak and lift their work just a little higher.”*

Huida returns to that modesty at the article’s close, observing that the producer is as much a master of his profession as the musicians themselves.

SOURCE Jarmo Huida, Satakunnan Kansa, 13 September 2014, Culture, pp. 10–11. Cover headline: “Täydellisyyden tavoittelija” (“The Perfectionist”).
An English adaptation with selected translated quotations; not a full translation of the original article.